dynasty, in which it says Yongle ‘wanted to display his soldiers in strange lands to make manifest the wealth and power of the Middle Kingdom’. It adds that the Ming armadas ‘went in succession to the various foreign countries, proclaiming the edicts of the Son of Heaven and giving gifts to their rulers and chieftains. Those who did not submit were pacified by force.’

The sting is in the tail!

There are three recorded instances of Zheng He engaging in military operations. During his return from his first voyage, Zheng He attacked the Indonesian port of Palembang which was then ruled by a Chinese pirate, Chen Zuyi, who had deposed the legitimate ruler. Chen Zuyi was defeated, taken prisoner and executed in Nanjing. The legitimate ruler was restored to the throne. This action also had a deterrent effect on piracy, which had become endemic in the South China Sea. On the third voyage, the Sri Lankan ruler Alagakkonara, who had been ‘arrogant and disrespectful and wanted to harm Zheng He’ on the latter’s first voyage, was defeated in a military operation and taken as prisoner to China, but was pardoned and sent back to the island. He was replaced by another member of the royal family who pledged allegiance to the Ming emperor. There was a third use of force on the last voyage, this time to punish a usurper to the throne of Samudera in Indonesia, which is present-day Aceh. In most cases, the appearance of the formidable Ming fleet was enough of a deterrent.

Zheng He’s voyages were also used to bring to China rulers and envoys from the several countries visited by the fleets. These envoys were expected to pay homage to the Ming emperor, offer tribute and receive expensive gifts in return. They were escorted back to their countries in subsequent voyages. The appearance of these foreign envoys in the Chinese capital reinforced the image of the emperor as lord of ‘All Under Heaven’, whose legitimacy was acknowledged far and wide.

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These voyages were no doubt a drain on the exchequer and were opposed by the Confucian bureaucracy. There was also bitter opposition to the